

Eoraptor

Eoraptor was one of the earliest dinosaurs. Its name means “dawn thief” in recognition of its place at the dawn of the dinosaur era. About the size of a fox, *Eoraptor* stood and ran quickly on its two hind legs. It killed prey by using its claws and teeth to tear the victim apart.

Moon reptile

The first *Eoraptor* fossils were discovered in 1991 in the Valley of the Moon, a region in northwestern Argentina. It is a barren landscape of bare rock, and looks like the surface of the Moon. When *Eoraptor* lived there in the Late Triassic the area was a lush river valley.

Eoraptor

EE-oh-rap-tor

- **When** 230–225 million years ago (Middle Triassic)
- **Fossil location** Argentina
- **Habitat** River valleys
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Lizards, small reptiles, sometimes plants

Only one complete fossil skeleton of *Eoraptor* has been found so far, but it reveals much about early dinosaurs. *Eoraptor* had primitive features, including five fingers on its front limbs, weak claws, and lizardlike hips. Scientists are not sure whether it had scales or feathers. *Eoraptor* is thought to have been a fierce and quick-witted hunter.

Strong thigh bones and muscles helped *Eoraptor* to stand upright.